Unity Data Model Summary of Changes

SIF Data Model Implementation Specification (NA) 4.4

DRAFT — Updated: October 24, 2026

Editor's notes appear in bracketed italics and must be resolved before release.

V 4.4 Scope:

1. Student Participation Flexibility
2. Discipline Incident Precision
3. Student Attendance Summary Identity
4. State Requests
5. Examples for Every Object
6. CEDS Alignment Cleanup

Release Location: https://files.a4l.org/Implementation/NA/4.4/

Student Participation Made Flexible

Unity implementations have historically represented program membership through program-specific flags inside StudentPersonal. That approach is simple and widely deployed, but it reflects only the current state of participation and offers no native way to carry entry and exit timelines, multiple participation periods in the same program, or program-centric events. This release elevates StudentParticipation to a first-class, time-bound representation of a student's participation in a specific program and documents three conformance-safe patterns: Traditional (StudentPersonal-centric), Hybrid, and Transactional (StudentParticipation-centric). The former requirement to generate a new instance and a new RefId every time a participation profile changes has been removed. Implementations that use both objects must define which one is authoritative for each program and how the two are kept in sync. Three optional elements were also added to support Title III and Title VI reporting: TitleIIILIEPInterventionStrategy, TribalAffiliation, and TribalCitizenMember.

See: StudentPersonal, StudentParticipation

Discipline Incident Clarified

DisciplineIncident contained several overlapping structures at the incident and offender levels, and the specification never said which to use when. Each DisciplineIncident is now explicitly defined as a single offense, so more than one may exist for the same time period and the same people. The descriptions of RelatedToList, WeaponTypeList, IncidentActionList and the offender-level RelatedToList, WeaponTypeList and ActionList were rewritten to state when a fact belongs to the whole incident and when it is attributed to an offender. Victims gained their own optional RelatedToList and ActionList so that secondary circumstances and actions taken for a victim, such as relocation or rescheduling for safety, finally have a standardized home. At Idaho's request, IncidentDate,

IncidentTime, IncidentLocation, IncidentReporter, IncidentCategory and its Code, and Offender/Injury are no longer mandatory. The incorrect CEDS mapping on IncidentActionList was dropped. These changes have been approved by the NA Interoperability Leader Group.

See: DisciplineIncident

Student Attendance Summary Identity

Providers that recompute StudentAttendanceSummary on every response tend to issue a fresh RefId each time, which forces consumers into delete-and-reinsert churn and prevents treating the object as a stable reporting-period record. The proposal for this release keeps the legacy transient RefId as valid behavior and adds an optional persistent mode in which a provider returns the same RefId for the same logical record, identified by StudentPersonalRefId, StudentSchoolEnrollmentRefId, SchoolInfoRefId, SchoolYear and CalendarSummaryRefId, across responses and Sync operations. SIF_Events are now reported for this object, allowing a student information system that knows its own calendar to push an accurate attendance picture to the state without query coordination.

See: StudentAttendanceSummary

State Requests Honored

Idaho and Wyoming brought forward several practical obstacles to adoption. For Idaho, OperationalStatusDate on LEAInfo and SchoolInfo is now optional, in addition to the DisciplineIncident relaxations described above. For Wyoming, TermInfo gained an optional CalendarSummaryRefId attribute so date-granularity questions about a term can be answered against its calendar, and the Function element of a FinancialAnnual item is now optional because it only applies once an item has been acquired. The FundingSource element within StudentProgramAssociation now carries a Codeset attribute like the other coded elements in the model.

See: LEAInfo, SchoolInfo, TermInfo, FinancialAnnual, StudentProgramAssociation, DisciplineIncident

Examples for Every Object

Every object in the data model now ships with a matched pair of JSON and XML examples, generated from the same source so the two representations are guaranteed to agree. The specification grew from 161 examples to 319 across 158 objects. The “Example Conventions” section was updated to explain that XML examples are shown as if they were inside a collection, so no namespace declaration appears. The complete set is also published as examples_US_4.4 in JSON and YAML alongside the OpenAPI documents.

See: Section 2.2.3 Example Conventions, JSON/examples_US_4.4

xPress and Infrastructure Alignment

The xPress reference objects carried inside xTransferIep were previously typed as the full xStudent, xStaff, xContact and xLea objects. They now use dedicated xStudentObjectType, xStaffObjectType, xContactObjectType and xLeaObjectType definitions, and xStudent itself is now an extension of xStudentObjectType, which keeps the standalone objects and the embedded references from drifting apart. The background documentation also gained the Infrastructure JSON bundle, providing OpenAPI 3.0 and 3.1 renderings of the SIF Infrastructure Specification 3.x.

See: xStudent, xTransferIep, Background Documentation (InfrastructureJSON.zip)

CEDS Alignment Cleanup

A community review of the CEDS alignment identified fourteen mappings that were wrong or no longer mappable, including the AssessmentSubTest item count (adaptive assessments vary it), the separate SSN element on EmployeeCredential, and several SEAInfo, SchoolCourseInfo, StudentContactRelationship and assessment-score elements pointing at the wrong CEDS identifier. In this draft the CEDS Id/URL column has been removed from the object tables, the XSD annotations and the implementation spreadsheet. While a CEDS alignment for this version is not being published alongside the release due to CEDS transitioning to an ontology, updated code sets are includes in the spreadsheet based on CEDS version 14.